



The Kennicott Glacier

A spectacular and accessible glacier in the Wrangell–St. Elias National Park of south central Alaska

The Kennicott Glacier flows down from the southern Wrangell Mountains, its principal source of ice being the flanks of Mount Blackburn—a snow-clad, eroded, extinct volcano and the fifth highest peak in the U.S. The glacier is about 26 miles (42 km) long.

Arms and tributaries

The upper part of the Kennicott Glacier has two arms, west and east, that flow around a ridge of rock and a nunatak (a small rocky peak poking through the ice) known as Packsaddle Island. After these two arms have joined, the impressively striped main trunk of the glacier flows south, where it merges with two large tributaries—the Gates and Root Glaciers—and later passes an abandoned mining community called Kennecott. It ends in a broad, rock-covered snout, surrounded by shallow meltwater pools and lakes. Several streams emerge from underneath the glacier and merge to form the Kennicott River.

The Kennicott Glacier and Root Glacier are accessible from a road built to supply the old mining camp. Guided hikes onto the glaciers provide a chance to view the ice formations, as well as vivid blue pools and streams on the glaciers' surfaces, or to explore the ice caves underneath them. Crossing the Root Glacier gives access to Donoho Peak. A strenuous scramble up this can give brilliant views of the whole area.

The glacier has **lost** about **245 ft (75 m)** of its **thickness** since the 1960s

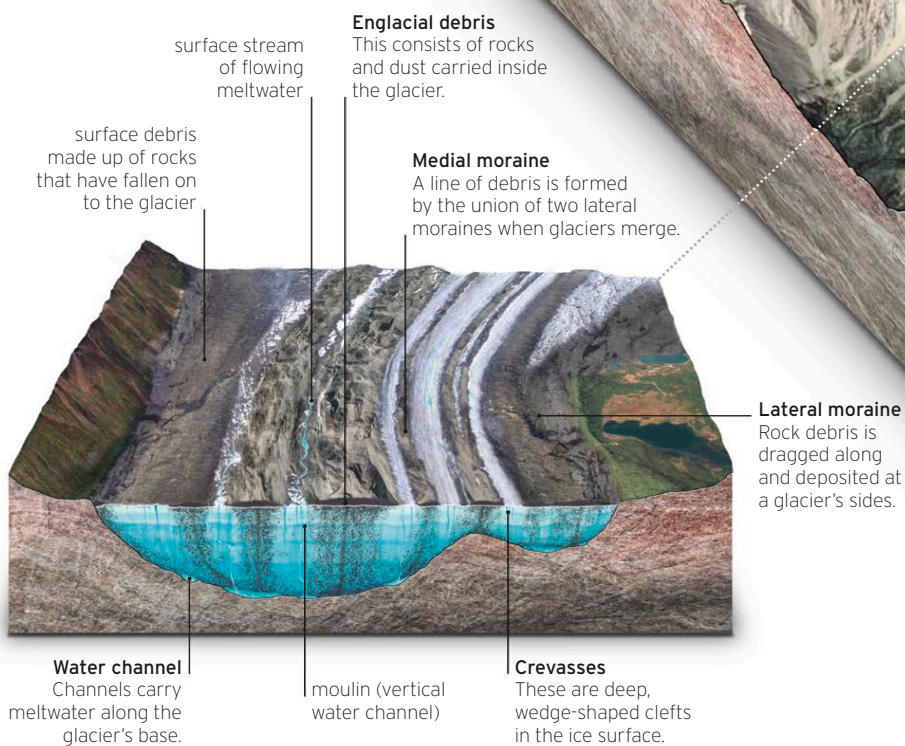
▷ SUBGLACIAL CAVE

Under the glacier's edge is a world of glowing blue ice, dripping water, and light seeping through cracks. These caves can be safely visited only at certain times of year due to seasonal flood risks.



► KENNICOTT GLACIER

Kennicott is a typical valley glacier—one hemmed in by surrounding mountains. It covers an area of about 100 square miles (250 square km). The full length of the glacier is shown here, flowing down from Mount Blackburn to its terminus at the head of the Kennicott River.



△ ANATOMY OF A VALLEY GLACIER

A typical valley glacier like the Kennicott is hundreds of feet deep at its center and contains rock debris on its surface, inside it, and dragged along at its sides and base. The ice is not solid but fractured by crevasses and carved by meltwater channels.